

CASSIDY SHUBATT

cshubatt@g.harvard.edu
cshubatt.github.io



HARVARD
UNIVERSITY

Littauer Center M35
1805 Cambridge St
Cambridge, MA 02138

Placement Director: Myrto Kalouptsi myrto@fas.harvard.edu (617) 496-0832
Placement Director: Oleg Itskhoki itskhoki@fas.harvard.edu (617) 495-2144
Administrative Director: Brenda Piquet bpiquet@harvard.edu (617) 495-8927

Education

Harvard University

Ph.D., Economics, 2027 (expected)

University of Iowa

B.S., Economics and Mathematics, *summa cum laude*, 2019

Fields

Experimental economics
Behavioral economics

References

Katherine Coffman
Harvard University
kcoffman@hbs.edu

Benjamin Enke
Massachusetts Institute of Technology
benjamin.enke@gmail.com

Sendhil Mullainathan
Massachusetts Institute of Technology
sendhil@mit.edu

Joshua Schwartzstein
Harvard University
jschwartzstein@hbs.edu

Teaching

Microeconomic Theory (Ph.D.), Harvard University, Jerry Green and Shengwu Li, 2025-26
Cognitive Economics (Ph.D.), Harvard University, Andrei Shleifer and Joshua Schwartzstein, 2025
Experimental Economics (Ph.D.), Harvard University, Benjamin Enke, 2024
Economics and Morality (undergraduate), Benjamin Enke, 2023
Stata/R Tutor, Harvard University, 2024-2025

Research

Research Assistant to Matthew Rabin, Harvard University, 2024
Research Assistant to Yannai Gonczarowski, Harvard University, 2023
Research Assistant to Benjamin Enke, Harvard University, 2021
Research Assistant to Sendhil Mullainathan and Ziad Obermeyer, University of Chicago Booth School of Business, 2019–2021

Job Market Paper

[Designing Experiments to Distinguish Theories](#)
with Baiyun Jing

We develop a measure of an experimental design's ability to distinguish between competing parametric theories. A design separates a theory from its competitors when these competitors are unable to reproduce behavior predicted by the theory. We propose an algorithmic procedure for constructing maximally-separating experimental designs, given a domain and hypothesized parameter values. Using this procedure, we generate 60 algorithmic designs to distinguish between competing theories of choice under risk. We show experimentally that designs with high separation generate stronger statistical results; and that experimental results are more likely to favor a given theory when separation is asymmetric, i.e. high for the theory, low for its competitor. We then use distinguishability to analyze a novel dataset of 123 lottery choice experiments from the experimental risk literature. We provide suggestive evidence that algorithmic designs substantially improve upon the state of the art for design development and demonstrate how distinguishability may change the interpretation of canonical experimental results.

Working Papers

Quantifying Lottery Choice Complexity

with Benjamin Enke

Revise and Resubmit at Econometrica

Using theory and experiments, this paper shows that the difficulty of making tradeoffs offers a parsimonious explanation for a wide range of behavioral phenomena. We develop a model of imprecise comparisons applicable to multiattribute, lottery, and intertemporal choice, which formalizes the idea that comparisons are difficult when they involve pronounced tradeoffs. Our model rationalizes a range of documented regularities, such as context effects, preference reversals, apparent probability weighting and hyperbolic discounting, and generates novel implications for behavior. We assess the explanatory power of our model in a series of choice experiments. Our model explains a large share of the variation in choice inconsistency across problems, and we document that manipulating tradeoffs reverses classic behavioral regularities, in line with its predictions.

Tradeoffs and Comparison Complexity

with Jeffrey Yang

This paper develops a theory of how tradeoffs govern the difficulty of comparisons. In our model, options are easier to compare when they involve less pronounced tradeoffs — when they are 1) more similar feature-by-feature and 2) closer to dominance. These postulates yield tractable measures of comparison complexity in three domains: multiattribute, lottery, and intertemporal choice. Our model rationalizes multiple behavioral regularities, such as context effects, preference reversals, and apparent probability weighting and hyperbolic discounting. In choice data spanning all three domains, our model predicts errors, inconsistency, and cognitive uncertainty. Manipulating tradeoffs reverses classic behavioral regularities, in line with model predictions.

Valuations Under Tradeoff Complexity

with Jeffrey Yang

Valuation tasks are a workhorse method for testing theories of individual preferences. However, a body of evidence suggests that complexity produces systematic measurement error in valuations, which raises the question of how researchers should interpret and utilize valuation data. To formally study this issue, we develop a model of complexity-driven noise in the valuation of risky prospects, in which the difficulty of comparing options to prices produces systematic noise in their valuations. We show how this model of noise can explain a number of documented valuation patterns that are difficult to rationalize under prevailing theories of risk preferences, as well as novel experimental evidence of systematic inconsistencies across valuation formats. We then characterize which valuation-based tests of preferences are robust to complexity in our model. While complexity distorts the levels of valuations in our model, differences between valuations can be informative, so long as complexity is held fixed across valuation tasks. We provide a formal criterion for robustness and apply it to valuation designs in the literature.

Seminars & Conferences

2026: New England Economics Ph.D. Conference; Behavioral Economics Annual Meeting, Graduate Student Workshop; Caltech Workshop in Theory-Driven Experiments; SITE Experimental Economics; The Choice Symposium; University of Iowa Job Market Conference

2025: Caltech Summer School in Theory-Driven Experiments, attendee

2024: Machine Learning in Economics Summer Institute, attendee

Academic Service

Referee: *Quarterly Journal of Economics*, *Econometrica*, *American Economic Review*, *Journal of the European Economic Association*, *American Economic Journal: Microeconomics*, *Management Science*, *Games and Economic Behavior*, *Experimental Economics*, *Economic Journal*, *Journal of Behavioral and Experimental Economics*

Organizer: Graduate Student Workshop in Behavioral Economics (2024-2026)

Research Grants	John and Kiendl Gordon Economics Support Fund, Harvard University (2026)
	Chae Family Economics Research Fund, Harvard University (2024)
Software Skills	Proficient in Stata, R, Python, $\text{\LaTeX}$, Git, and Excel